

Stress Management

Understanding stress and evidence-based strategies for coping with it

Introduction

Stress is something almost everyone experiences at some point in life. In small amounts, stress can be helpful, sharpening focus and preparing the body to respond to challenges. In larger or more sustained amounts, however, stress can affect both physical and mental health. This document explains what stress is, what causes it, how it shows up in the body and mind, and evidence-based ways to manage it effectively.

What is Stress?

Stress affects both the mind and the body. A little bit of stress is good and can help people perform daily activities, but too much stress can cause physical and mental health problems. Learning how to cope with stress can help people feel less overwhelmed and support both mental and physical well-being.

(Source: WHO)

It is natural to feel stressed in challenging situations such as job interviews, exams, unrealistic workloads, job insecurity, or conflict with family, friends, or colleagues. For many people, stress reduces over time as the situation improves or as they learn to cope with it emotionally. Stress tends to become more widespread during events such as major economic crises, disease outbreaks, natural disasters, or community violence.

(Source: WHO)

MedlinePlus describes stress as a normal and healthy reaction to change or a challenge. However, stress that continues for more than a few weeks can begin to affect health. It is possible to become used to the symptoms of stress without realizing there is a problem, so it is important to pay attention to how stress is affecting you.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Causes

Stress is caused by stressors: situations or demands, internal or external, that trigger the body's stress response. Common stressors include family conflict, school or work pressures, relationship difficulties, financial problems, and health concerns.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

- Major life events, such as a job loss, divorce, bereavement, or serious illness.

- Chronic pressures, such as an overwhelming workload, financial strain, or ongoing relationship difficulties.
- Significant life changes, including positive ones such as marriage, a new job, or having a child, since any change requires adjustment and adaptation.
- Broader societal events, such as economic crises, disease outbreaks, natural disasters, or community violence, which can cause widespread stress.

(Source: WHO, MedlinePlus)

Risk Factors

- Experiencing multiple stressful events within a short period of time, since their cumulative effect can be significant.
- Lack of social support or feeling isolated from family and friends.
- Existing physical or mental health conditions, which chronic stress can worsen.
- Reliance on unhealthy coping behaviors, such as alcohol, tobacco, or other substance use, to manage stress.
- High-demand environments, such as certain workplaces or caregiving roles, that involve ongoing pressure.

(Source: WHO, MedlinePlus)

Common Symptoms

Stress can produce a wide range of physical, emotional, and behavioral symptoms, and everyone experiences stress somewhat differently.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

- Feeling anxious, irritable, or overwhelmed.
- Difficulty concentrating or relaxing.
- Headaches or other body pains.
- Upset stomach or other digestive problems.
- Trouble sleeping.
- Loss of appetite, or eating more than usual.
- Increased use of alcohol, tobacco, or other substances.

(Source: WHO, MedlinePlus)

Chronic stress, meaning stress that persists over weeks or longer, can worsen pre-existing health problems and can also cause or worsen mental health conditions, most commonly anxiety and depression, which may require professional health care.

(Source: WHO)

Diagnosis

Stress itself is not a diagnosable medical condition in the way that a specific disorder is, but a health care provider can assess whether stress is contributing to physical symptoms, anxiety, depression, or other health conditions. Recognizing stress in one's own life is the first step toward managing it: noticing personal signs of stress, such as anger, irritability, sleep loss, headaches, or an upset stomach, and identifying the situations, or stressors, that trigger these signs.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Evidence-Based Approaches to Managing Stress

The World Health Organization has developed a self-help stress management guide, "Doing What Matters in Times of Stress," designed to equip people with practical skills to cope with stress; the guide notes that just a few minutes a day practicing its techniques can be beneficial. If a person has ongoing difficulty coping with stress, seeking help from a trusted health care provider or another trusted person in the community is recommended.

(Source: WHO)

- Identifying stressors: understanding where stress is coming from is the first step toward developing ways to address it.
- Recognizing what can and cannot be changed: accepting things that cannot be changed can reduce the ongoing burden of trying to control the uncontrollable.
- Avoiding or reducing exposure to specific stressful situations when possible.
- Getting regular exercise, which triggers the release of brain chemicals that improve mood.
- Building and maintaining supportive relationships with family and friends.

(Source: MedlinePlus, WHO)

Healthy Lifestyle Recommendations

Everyday lifestyle habits play an important role in the body's ability to cope with stress over time.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

- Getting regular exercise, such as a 30-minute daily walk, which can improve mood and help keep the immune system strong.
- Getting enough sleep every night, since good-quality sleep helps the body recover from stress.
- Limiting caffeine, since excess caffeine can worsen feelings of stress and anxiety.
- Eating regular, balanced meals to help maintain stable energy and mood.

- Avoiding alcohol and drugs as coping mechanisms, since these provide only temporary relief and can worsen stress over time.

(Source: MedlinePlus, WHO)

Sleep and Stress

Getting enough sleep is important for both body and mind, since sleep helps repair, relax, and rejuvenate the body and can help reverse the effects of stress. Good sleep habits, sometimes called sleep hygiene, include going to bed and waking up at consistent times, keeping the sleeping area quiet, dark, and comfortable, limiting the use of electronic devices before bed, and avoiding large meals, caffeine, and alcohol close to bedtime.

(Source: WHO)

Self-Help Techniques

- Try relaxing activities, such as breathing exercises, meditation, or muscle relaxation exercises, which can be practiced through apps or wellness programs.
- Decide what needs to be done now and what can wait, and focus on what was accomplished each day rather than what was not.
- Ask family or friends for support, and share concerns and feelings with people you trust.
- Keep in touch with family and friends, since connecting with others can lift mood and reduce feelings of stress.
- Pay attention to what you eat and drink, since nutrition can affect overall health and the body's ability to manage stress.

(Source: MedlinePlus, WHO)

When to Seek Professional Help

Most people manage stress well and continue to function in daily life. However, professional help should be sought if a person has ongoing difficulty coping with stress on their own.

(Source: WHO)

- Severe stress symptoms lasting two weeks or more.
- Stress that is interfering with work, relationships, or daily responsibilities.
- Increasing reliance on alcohol, drugs, or other unhealthy behaviors to cope.
- Physical symptoms, such as persistent headaches or stomach problems, that do not improve.
- Feelings of being unable to cope, or the presence of thoughts of self-harm.

(Source: MedlinePlus, WHO)

A trusted health care provider or another trusted person in the community is a good starting point for anyone who is struggling to cope with stress on their own.

(Source: WHO)

Myths vs Facts

- **Myth:** All stress is harmful. **Fact:** A moderate amount of stress is a normal, even helpful, part of life and can improve performance and alertness; it is chronic or excessive stress that poses health risks.
- **Myth:** Stress will simply go away on its own if ignored. **Fact:** While stress often reduces as a situation improves, ignoring persistent stress can allow it to worsen physical and mental health over time.
- **Myth:** Using alcohol or substances is an effective way to relieve stress. **Fact:** These provide only temporary relief and can worsen stress and health outcomes over the longer term.
- **Myth:** Feeling stressed means a person cannot work or function. **Fact:** Most people experience stress and continue to manage their daily responsibilities effectively.

(Source: WHO, MedlinePlus)

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Is all stress bad for you?

A: No. A little stress is a normal and even useful part of daily life. It becomes a problem mainly when it is intense, prolonged, or chronic, since this type of stress can cause physical and mental health problems.

(Source: WHO)

Q: How can I tell if my stress is becoming a problem?

A: Signs that stress may be becoming a problem include ongoing symptoms such as trouble sleeping, headaches, digestive issues, irritability, or increased use of alcohol or other substances, especially if these symptoms last two weeks or more or interfere with daily life.

(Source: MedlinePlus, WHO)

Q: Can stress cause anxiety or depression?

A: Yes. Stressful situations can cause or worsen mental health conditions, most commonly anxiety and depression, which may require professional health care.

(Source: WHO)

Q: What is one simple thing I can do today to manage stress?

A: Getting regular physical activity, even a 30-minute walk, is one of the easiest and most effective ways to cope with stress, since exercise triggers the release of brain chemicals that improve mood.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Key Takeaways

- Stress is a normal response to change or challenge, and a moderate amount can be beneficial.
- Chronic or excessive stress can affect physical health, mental health, sleep, and behavior.
- Identifying personal stressors and signs of stress is the first step toward effectively managing it.
- Regular exercise, good sleep habits, balanced nutrition, and social support are evidence-based ways to build resilience to stress.
- Unhealthy coping behaviors, such as alcohol or substance use, provide only temporary relief and can worsen stress over time.
- Professional help should be sought if stress becomes overwhelming, persistent, or begins to affect daily functioning.

This document provides general educational information based on publicly available guidance from the World Health Organization and MedlinePlus. It is not a substitute for personalized medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult a qualified health care provider with questions about a specific medical condition.

References

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